Community Composting 101

Getting Started & Engaging the Community

Neighborhood Soil Rebuilders
COMPOSTER TRAINING PROGRAM

ILSR
INSTITUTE FOR Local Self-Reliance

Getting Started & Engaging the Community

- ✔ **Getting Started**
  - Clarifying goals
  - Collection vs. composting
  - Entity structure
- ✔ **Engaging the Community**
  - Signage
  - Managing volunteers
- ✔ **Parting Thoughts**

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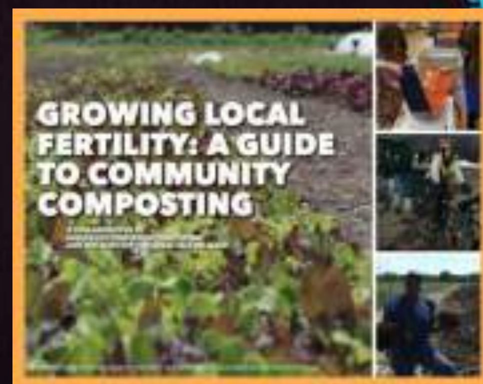
Getting Started: Planning Steps

- ✔ Step 1: Clarify goals
- ✔ Step 2: Decide which parts of the process to undertake
- ✔ Step 3: Identify potential partners and collaborators
- ✔ Step 4: Select materials to compost and collect
- ✔ Step 5: Research food scrap generators and other sources of material
- ✔ Step 6: Plan your compost site
- ✔ Step 7: Learn state and local zoning, permitting, and regulatory requirements
- ✔ Step 8: Develop a financial plan
- ✔ Step 9: Organize finances
- ✔ Step 10: Identify potential funding sources
- ✔ Step 11: Assess project feasibility
- ✔ Step 12: Define your project



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Getting Started: BMP Guide

https://ilsr.org/composting-bmp-guide/

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Clarify Goals

- **SAMPLE:** The primary goal of the ROT ON COMPOST PROJECT is to produce a high-quality compost for use on Breezy Fields Farm. A secondary goal is to create a revenue source through sale of compost.
- **SAMPLE:** The primary goal of the TREE TOP NATURE & REC CENTER FOOD SCRAP RECYCLING PROGRAM is to educate and engage the community on how to drop off and compost their kitchen scraps.

ECO City Farms:

mission is growing food






Photos: ILSR
Chris Cano (bottom left)

Photos: ECO City Farms

St. John's University

reduce waste, engage students in academic learning, grow food for local pantries

Right Photos: St. John's University

Left Photos: ILSR

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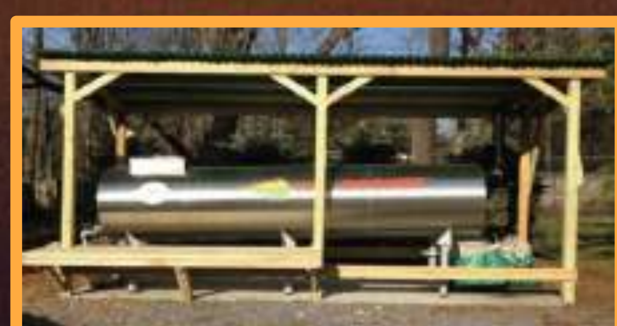
Rippowam Cisqua School:

save money, involve students, use compost in school garden



Photos: Food Waste Experts and Rippowan Cisqua School website (right)

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BK ROT

Provide jobs & professional development for emerging environmental leaders

Photo: @BK_Rot

Windrows

Photo: @BK_Rot

Bike collection

Photo: Valery Rizzo

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DC's Community Compost Cooperative Network:

harness volunteer power to create compost for community gardens from local food scraps

DC Dept. of Parks & Recs Compost Cooperative Sites

Photos: ILSR

Map: DC Department of Parks & Recreation

Photo DC Department of Parks & Recreation

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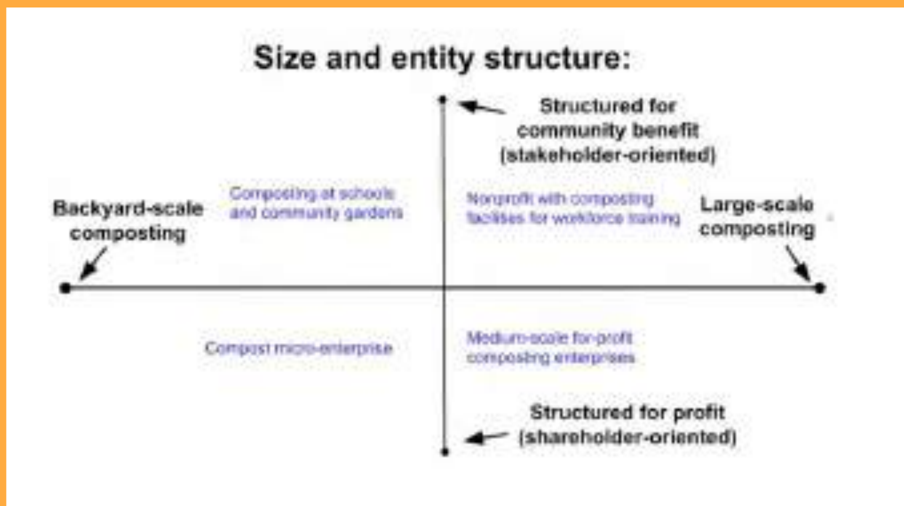
Decide which parts of the process to undertake

- Collection?
- Composting?
- Using compost?
- Selling compost?
- Education?

Are you a new organization? What entity structure to choose?

https://ilsr.org/webinar-entity-structure-for-community-composters-november-2018/

- Nonprofit 501(c)3
- B-Corp
- LLC
- Other for-profit
- Social enterprise
- Cooperative
- Institution (e.g., university, K-12 school)
- Government



https://ilsr.org/webinar-entity-structure-for-community-composters-november-2018/

Identify potential partners and collaborators

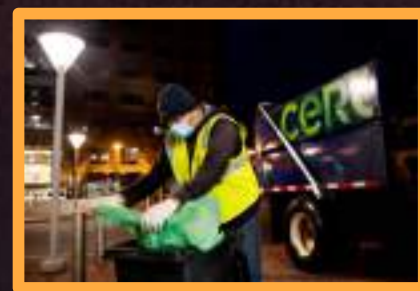
Kelly Miller Middle School, DC
Partnership: DC DPR, Dreaming Out Loud, DC DPW, Loop Closing

Photos: ILSR

Select materials to accept
Sourced from where?

Photos: ILSR.

Baltimore Compost Collective



CERO, Boston area

Photos: CERO website https://www.cero.coop (top), CERO twitter, via Matthew Modoono/Northeastern University (bottom)

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ACCEPTABLE MATERIALS

✓ YES

GREENS

- FRUIT & VEGETABLE SCRAPS (No stickers)
- EGG SHELLS
- COFFEE GROUNDS & PAPER FILTERS
- TEA BAGS (No staples or plastic)
- GARDEN TRIMMINGS (6" or smaller)

BROWNS

- FALL LEAVES
- PLANT STALKS (6" or smaller)
- WOOD CHIPS & SHAVINGS (Not chemically treated)
- SHREDDED NEWSPAPER & BROWN BAGS (No glossy pages)

✗ NO

- MEAT, FISH, OR BONES
- EGGS OR DAIRY PRODUCTS
- PRODUCE STICKERS
- GLOSSY PAPER
- DISEASED AND PEST-INFESTED PLANTS
- WEEDS WITH SEEDS
- "COMPOSTABLE" TABLEWARE & PLASTIC BAGS
- FATS, OILS, OR GREASE
- COOKED FOOD
- PET WASTE & KITTY LITTER
- TREATED OR PAINTED WOOD
- HERBICIDE-TREATED PLANTS
- DRYER LINT
- USED TISSUES

Developed by the Institute for Local Self-Reliance

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From where will you source your carbon?

Austin community site

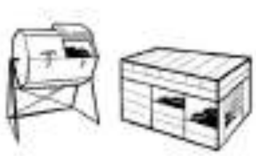
Red Hook Community Farm Compost Operation, Brooklyn, NYC

Wood shavings at Prospect Heights Community Garden, Brooklyn

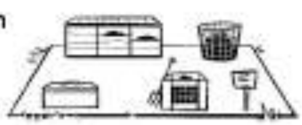
Photos ILSR

GETTING STARTED

1. **Choose system** (open or closed, DIY or brand, batch or continuous flow)



2. **Locate bins or system** (good drainage; convenient access, near water source; room to move around)



3. **Set up storage for browns** (carbon source or bulking materials)

4. **Have tools accessible** (pitch fork, bucket, temperature probe, scale)

5. **Post instructions for participants**

6. **Build a pile** (either layer browns and greens, or add greens to a big pile of browns)

7. **Aerate and mix as needed** (e.g., aim for weekly for first few weeks, or based on temperature or odor)

8. **Check and adjust moisture as needed**

9. **After 8 to 12 weeks, harvest finished compost**

10. **Screen**

11. **Store finished compost**

Signage!

Have clear signage and instructions!

Photo: ILSR

Prospect Heights Community Farm, Brooklyn, NY

Directions!

DIY Signage

Photos: ILSR

East Capitol Urban Farm, District of Columbia

Photos: ILSR

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Photos: ILSR

More Sign Examples

Photo: LA Compost

LA Compost

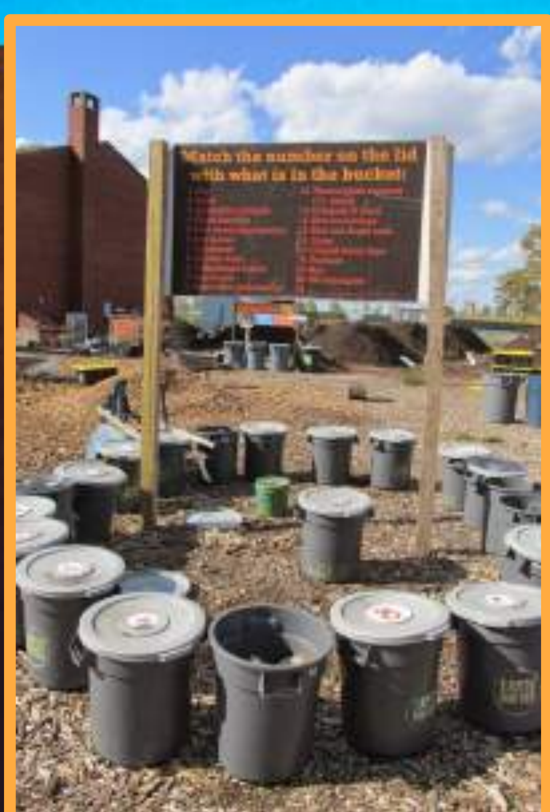
Photo: LA Compost

Earth Matter, NYC

Photos: ILSR

Photos: ILSR

Earth Matter, NYC



Photos: ILSR

Sunshine Compost, Sarasota area, Florida

Photo ILSR

Photos: ILSR

Drop-off: Chittenden Solid Waste District, VT

Source: Chittenden Solid Waste District. Provided to ILSR as part of BioCycle Residential Food Waste Collection Access In The U.S., 2017.

Drop-off: South Portland, ME

Source: South Portland Office of Sustainability. Provided to ILSR as part of BioCycle Residential Food Waste Collection Access In The U.S., 2017.

Educational Signage too!

Permanent composting education exhibit and workshop venue, Chula Vista Nature Center, City of Chula Vista, California

Source: Hidden Resources, www.compostingconsultant.com

Photo ILSR

Queens Botanical Garden: Training, Demo Site

Photos: ILSR

Educational Signage

Photos: ILSR

Queens Botanical Garden

Queens Botanical Garden

Queens Botanical Garden

Photos: ILSR

Baltimore Office of Sustainability


THE LAND TRUST FOR TENNESSEE
WELCOME TO
Glen Leven Farm's
COMPOSTING SITE
TURNING FOOD SCRAPS INTO SOIL!
FOR MORE INFO, VISIT:
Neighborhood Soil Rebuilders
ILSR
LAND TRUST TENNESSEE
FOOD WASTE


FOOD SCRAP DROP-OFF INSTRUCTIONS
1 UNLOCK the drop-off bin and tool station
2 RECORD weight of container scraps (minus container weight) in the log
3 ADD your food scraps to the drop-off bin
4 COVER all food scraps with a 4 inch layer of BROWNS
5 RECORD odor or other observations in the log
6 CLOSE and LOCK all bins!
Developed by the Institute for Local Self-Reliance

Engaging Volunteers & Participants

DC Department of Public Works

Photos: ILSR

Department of Parks and Recreation

Community Compost Cooperative Network

The DC Parks and Recreation (DPR) Community Compost Cooperative Network uses new critter proof and smell proof compost bins designed by Urban Farm Plans to allow trained community members to compost food scraps with garden waste from DPR and partner DPR gardens to responsibly create high quality compost. To join each member must take an hour training and help process compost 1-hour a month.

(Photo Credit for Compost bin: Urban Farm Plans)

Each cooperative can handle around 100 active composters or about 1 ton of material a month. DPR currently has 50 cooperative compost sites with a capacity of 5000 people actively composting or 50 tons of material a month with no operating costs and no carbon footprint. Currently there are more than 1000 people composting around 20 tons a month in this network.

https://dpr.dc.gov/page/community-compost-cooperative-network

<u>Requirements for Cooperative</u>

<u>1-3 Co-op Manager(s)</u>

(Can't start a co-op without at least 1 manager. About 3 hours of work a month)

Responsibilities

1. Train future co-op members (will be trained to do this)
2. Organize once a month work day
3. Quality control

<u>Coop Members</u>

Responsibilities

1. Take a 1-hour training
2. Help process compost 1-hour a month
3. Provide an active form of communication

Compost Cooperative Training

What is compost?

Method

4 Components of Compost

1. Green Material

Acceptable Green (High in Nitrogen) Materials

Acceptable Green Materials that must be coordinated with Manager due to extremely high levels of Nitrogen.

2. Brown Material

Acceptable Brown (High in Carbon) Materials

Process

Step 1. Adding fresh food and garden waste

Brown 2:1 Green

- **There should never be any exposed rotting food ever!**

ECUF Compost Project Agreement

I hereby agree to abide to the following rules and conditions at the East Capital Urban Farm Composting site. As a member, I will be required to:
*Volunteer at least 1 hour per month at the site.
*Abide to the drop-off rules and help other members.
*Follow carefully the Yes and No of composting.
*Report unusual activities or smells.

Date	Printed Name	Signature	Email & Phone (put a * next to your prefered form of communication)
8/5/17	[redacted]		
8/5/17			
8/5/17			
8/5/17			
8/5/17			
8/5/17			
8-5-17			
8/5/17			

Greenbelt (MD) - Zero Waste Circle
Volunteer-based collective, 800 lbs/week

THE HOTS – all-volunteer community of ~60 families manage the 3-bin system

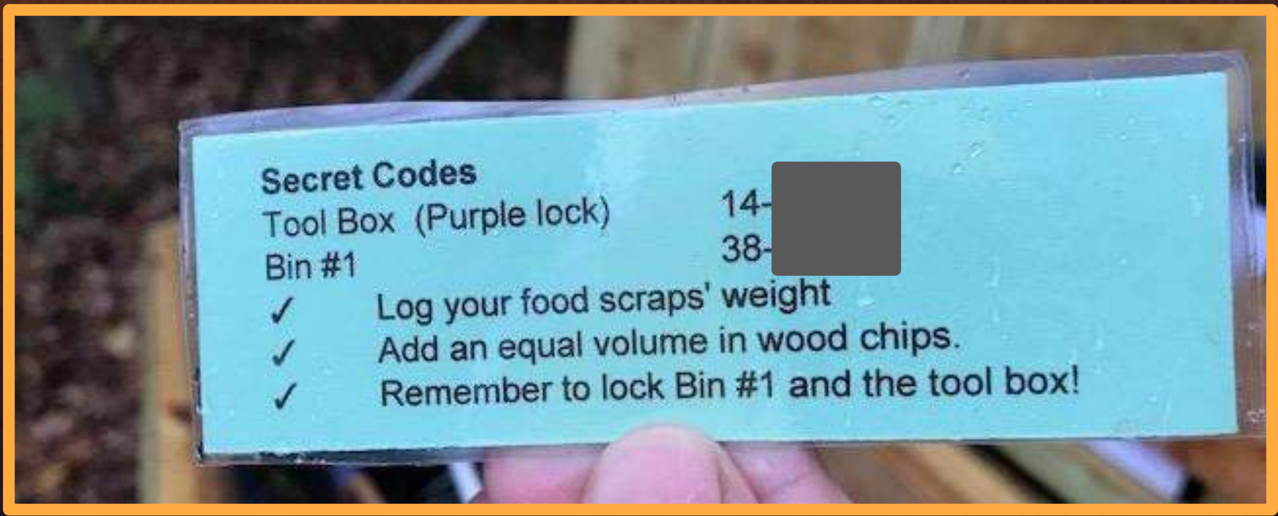
THE WIGGLERS – another volunteer group manages the vermicomposting system at the New Deal Café

https://www.greenbeltmd.gov/government/departments-con-t/public-works/trash-recycling/community-compost-program

Greenbelt, Maryland Dept. of Public Works built the tool storage bin and the concrete pad.

Photos: ILSR; Greenbelt Public Works website (bottom right photo)

Greenbelt walk-through with new participants



Red Hook Community Farm, NYC

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BymDL3hMTXs&t=6s

Photos: http://www.added-value.org/compost (top), ILSR (bottom and right)

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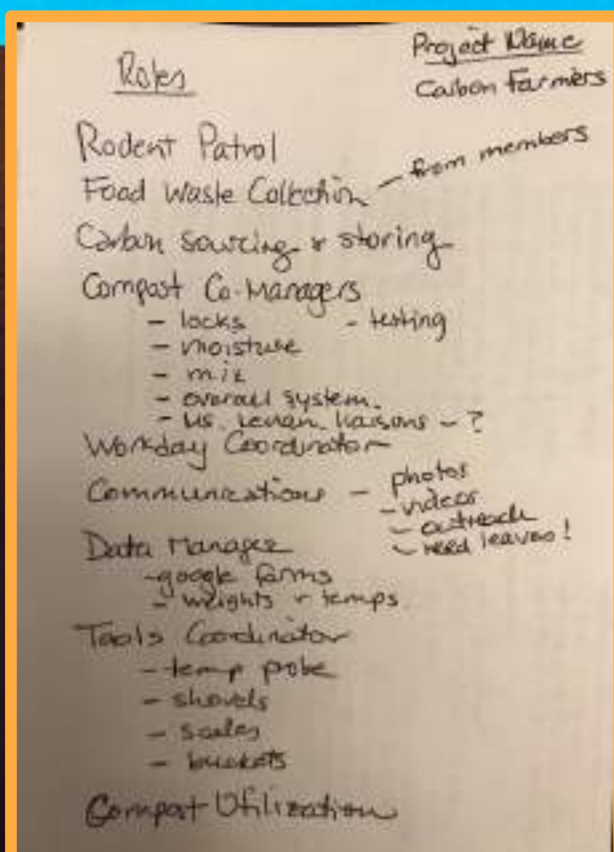
Consider creating subteams or roles



Roles

Project Name
Carbon Farmers

Rodent Patrol
Food Waste Collection – from members
Carbon sourcing & storing
Compost Co-Managers
- locks - testing
- moisture
- mix
- overall system
- us. leven. liaisons – ?

Workday Coordinator
Communications – photos
- videos
- outreach
- need leaves!

Data Manager
- google forms
- weights & temps

Tools Coordinator
- temp probe
- shovels
- scales
- buckets

Compost Utilization

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Parting Thoughts

- ✔ Build slowly!
- ✔ Operate according to your limitations. What is your limiting factor:
  - human capacity,
  - volume,
  - feedstock,
  - space,
  - funding/resources,
  - regulatory environment?
- ✔ Avoid team burnout
- ✔ Ensure compost operator is trained
- ✔ Follow best management practices

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